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Failure and Happening in Metatheatres: Representations of Violence in Contemporary Black Theatre

In his 2015 book, *Between the World and Me*, Ta-Nehisi Coates explains that “race is the child of racism, not the father” (7). By connecting racism to a heritage, Coates defines racism corporeally as “a visceral experience” which “dislodges brains, blocks airways, rips muscle, extracts organs, cracks bones, breaks teeth” (10). In her article “New black math,” Suzan-Lori Parks echoes his connection of racism to corporeality, locating it specifically in American history:

“A black play in the united states of america was ripped from the bosom of its motherland, caught by the man or sold down river by its brothers, crossed the atlantic in chains, [...] had its language ripped out its mouth, its family torn asunder” (579).

While race is a cultural construct and not part of the natural world, racism is part of the physical world because it is enacted upon the body. In Black plays, representations of blackness are always joined by some form of whiteness and, of course, “the presence of the white suggests-the presence of the black” (Parks 579). Not all Black drama requires an overt representation of the relationship of blackness and whiteness, but this relationship is always present in American drama: “Every play that is born of the united states of america is a black play because we all exist in the shadow of slavery. All of us.” (579). Whether blackness and whiteness interact visibly or invisibly, the interaction is predicated on violence. Because “blackness and performance are inextricably linked,” and performance shapes the “lived experience and political

possibilities of black Americans,” representations of violent interactions between blackness and whiteness wield great power to effect black Americans (Catanese 1).

In her article, “Black-Authored Lynching Drama’s Challenge to Theater History,” Koritha Mitchell criticizes American theater history’s lack of acknowledgement of “how compatible theater and lynching” were in the late-19th and early 20th centuries. As a young nation, the American theater needed to develop a canon of drama and “real-life lynching incidents provided the perfect mixture of danger, passion, and triumph with which to elaborate the uniquely American narrative of white bravery versus black barbarity” (Mitchell 95). However, she argues that the development of the lynching drama shows that black Americans in this time “recognized both sides of the theater/lynching partnership” (93). Black-authored lynching dramas moved the spectator gaze from the victim’s body, the focus of lynching narratives, to the black home to portray the terrible effects of lynchings on black families. American dramatists, white and black, during this time understood representations of racism have tangible effects on the lives of black Americans, just as racism has tangible effects on the physical body. If blackness is closely associated with performance, how does contemporary black drama, and all American drama, ethically represent violence enacted upon the black body onstage?

In “Violence Onstage and Off,” Russell Vandenbroucke looks at violence in contemporary American theatre in context with the history of violence onstage. In “the theatre’s gory past,” from Sophocles to Shakespeare to Sarah Kane, approaches to violence onstage morph and evolve reflecting the cultural values of society (Vandenbroucke 108). Distinguishing types of violence is necessary to discuss its function in contemporary dramaturgies—Vandenbroucke provides three definitions: *direct violence*, an intentional act of physical harm; *structural*

violence, “inequalities built into the social system”; and *cultural violence*, “any aspect of cultural that can be used to legitimize violence in its direct or structural form” (108). Pointing to well-known contemporary plays—*Disgraced*, *Ruined*, *Father Comes Home From the Wars*, *Fires in the Mirror*, *The Laramie Project*—Vandenbroucke illustrates the current “trend of structural violence supplanting direct stage violence” (112). While black drama of the 20th century places direct violence mostly offstage, or abstractly onstage, and rarely directly interrogates structural or cultural violence, black drama of the 21st century highlights structural violence and exposes cultural violence as well.

In this paper I will describe ethical approaches to representations of violence by analyzing moments of direct violence onstage in three contemporary plays: *An Octoroon*, by Branden Jacobs-Jenkins; *We Are Proud to Present A Presentation About the Herero of Namibia, Formerly Known as Southwest Africa, From the German Sudwestafrika, Between the Years 1884-1915*, by Jackie Sibblies Drury; and *Pass Over*, by Antoinette Nwandu. Branden Jacobs-Jenkins’s *An Octoroon* interrogates cultural representation through its self-referential adaptation-within-the-play of Dion Boucicault’s *The Octoroon*. In *We Are Proud*, Jackie Sibblies Drury exposes the insidious cultural violence which lies somewhat hidden just below the surface and continues to exert power on the behavior and performance of individuals. Antoinette Nwandu’s *Pass Over* depicts two black men unable to escape the institutional racism and structural violence embodied in and upheld by the police.

Each descendants of the lynching drama genre, these plays depict the three types of violence that comprise the lynching event: “back woods lynchings are *direct violence*; the assumption that the crimes, attitudes, and behavior of blacks explain their frequent victimization reflects *structural violence*; and the belief that black men are predisposed to commit crime,

especially the rape of white women, is *cultural violence*” (Vandenbroucke 117). While structural and cultural violence are more present in contemporary American theatre than in the past, the question of how to ethically represent direct violence onstage remains. Because in theatre the bodies of the actors are present with the audience, depictions of direct violence risk being acts of violence themselves and demand an ethical approach by theatre artists. In this paper I will analyze three contemporary Black plays and their representations of direct violence to argue that the theatre is best suited ontologically to interrogate the violence of contemporary America and American history and contemporary black dramatists deal with the terror of this violence primarily through metatheatricality.

In *Embodying Black Experience*, Harvey Young asks this ethical question of museum exhibitions and describes lynchings as “public performances,” with large audiences and complex narratives (113). Souvenirs commemorated these public performances, defined by Young as physical objects which embody the experience of an event when attached to a memory and a narrative: “The souvenir saves the past and represents it in the present. It records the *that which was* in a material object that can be referenced and revisited over time” (114). He discusses a few specific examples of souvenirs from lynchings—a piece of the rope used for the noose, a toe, and a postcard—but focuses on analyzing the exhibition of these artifacts in Dr. James Cameron’s America’s Black Holocaust Museum. Though he discusses museums, I will reference Young’s scholarship in this paper because the performance, narrative, and audience aspects he points to are applicable. Souvenirs of lynching performances in contemporary theatre include the images of victims’ bodies and stage props which records American history and “represents it in the present.”

The primary device of Dion Boucicault's plot in *The Octoroon* is a photograph revealed in Act IV of the play's villain, M'Closky, murdering Paul, a young black boy. In the prologue, BJJ (played by a black actor) explains directly to the audience why he decided to adapt the 19th century play and the casting problems he encountered, while he puts on whiteface makeup to perform the lead role because the white actor quit. The Playwright (Dion Boucicault, played by a white actor) joins him onstage to speak to the audience directly about his play as he dons red face make-up to perform the Native American character, Wahnotee.

From the beginning, Jacobs-Jenkins establishes a metatheatrical mode for the performance to interrogate representation of identity. Throughout the play, BJJ and Playwright interrupt to explain and comment on the action. When a performance alternates between the modes of reality and fiction, the audience's perception of the body of the performer onstage also alters from the actor being physically present and the actor representing the character. According to Erika Fischer-Lichte, when the audience experiences this rapid oscillation "the difference between the two [modes] increasingly loses its relevance," and the audience instead "focuses on the rupture of stability, the state of instability, and the passage" (19). At the beginning of Act IV, BJJ and Playwright explain the dramaturgy of Act IV, which in a melodrama is where you want "to really hit the audience with something big" (Jacobs-Jenkins 47). In the original play, that something is revealing the photograph of the murderer and victim.

In his adaptation, immediately after revealing the photograph, BJJ breaks character to acknowledge that photograph fails to shock today's audience and explains it was very novel for a 19th century audience. Once a representation of direct violence enacted upon a black body is revealed in the play-within-the-play, the performance stops and the metatheatrical mode takes over to handle the moment. BJJ and Playwright discuss various theatrical tricks they considered

to shock the audience, and finally BJJ tries something he hopes “isn’t too disappointing”: a projection of “*a lynching photograph*” replaces the photograph of the original play (51). The use of this image, intended to shock the audience as the original photograph did in the 19th century theatre, relies on the theatricality of lynchings to affect the audience viscerally. Koritha Mitchell explains that black Americans understood that “black bodies were central to lynching’s theatrical power and to theater’s signifying power, with both hinging on negative interpretations of the black body” (7). The play-within-the-play resumes for a few lines after the image is projected, but its theatrical and signifying power overpowers the action. BJJ breaks character again saying, “I can’t see anything. I’m sorry – Can we turn this off?” and then the performance continues (51).

Though not part of the story, the effect of the lynching photograph as a depiction of direct violence is threatening to the performer, audience, and the performance itself. Harvey Young argues photographs of lynchings displayed publicly “[threaten] to repeat and restage their past violence in the present” (128). Today, the images might terrify audiences by awakening a dormant awareness of human capacity for evil and, perhaps more uncomfortably, the violence of our American history. However, the lynching photographs function differently for a black viewer because the “terroristic value depends on their being seen by black people. [...] Black spectators are subjected to the violence committed *in* and *by* these photographs” (qtd. Young 128). Resurrected and transferred beyond its original temporal and spatial location, the violence committed in and by the photograph interrupts BJJ’s adaptation. Images of lynchings continue to inflict violence today, and representations of lynchings in theatre possess the same “terroristic value,” and the terror is more potent in live performance. Yet, by avoiding these representations as Americans often do, the violence is placed out of sight and expunged from American history.

In *We Are Proud*, Drury uses a similar metatheatrical mode by depicting six actors devising a play about the Herero genocide. The only available source material is a collection of letters from a German colonist to his German wife back home. With no physical evidence of the Herero story, the African perspective is omitted, causing disputes amongst the actors about the ethics of representation, storytelling, and historical facts. By combining metatheatricity with historical subject matter, Drury creates for the audience a “distance to diminish its defensiveness over its own responsibility for the social and structural order” until the end of the play (Vandenbroucke 110). As in *An Octoroon*, the audience experiences constant oscillation “between the phenomenal and the semiotic body, between the real and the fictional” (Fischer-Lichte 14). *We Are Proud*, which premiered in 2012 at the Soho Repertory Theatre, interrogates the ethics of representing violence on the black body in both form and content. In “Metatheatre and Dramaturgies of Reception,” Emma Willis analyzes this play and asks: “how does the metatheatrical form ‘do’ violence and to what effect?” (197). Willis concludes that “the play demonstrates the ethical and aesthetic challenges as well as the necessity of engaging with [American] history,” but she does not fully address the effect on the audience of alternating between reality and fiction (209). By the end, the audience is desensitized to the difference between reality and fiction onstage. The line demarcating represented violence and real violence also fades for the audience, and the performers as well.

The play requires a metatheatrical frame that acknowledges the tenuous separation from reality and fiction to orient both the audience and performers. Drury does this simply in the beginning with the pre-show announcement written into the prologue. In the “Process” scenes performed in one space of the stage, the six actors devise a play about the German genocide of the indigenous Herero of Namibia. In a separate space of the stage, they perform the

“Presentation” of their play, moving back and forth seamlessly between rehearsal and performance. In the final scene, called “Processtation,” the actors improv instructed by Actor 6, the leader, not to stop until she says so. The processtation evolves into chanting as White Man and Another White Man lead Black Man and Another Black Man to the Herero labor camp, then the chant “*turns into a song. A work song. Accents creep in as the song is sung and the chant is chanted*” (Drury 94). In this moment the actors slip unintentionally from representing the Herero/Germans, into a frighteningly easy, almost natural representation of black and white Americans vaguely located in the American South.

As the language becomes unmistakably American, Black Man is chased by White Man and Another White Man, accompanied by a rhythmic underscore of chants, claps, and stomps, until “*eventually the entire ensemble share the chants/song/dance*” (97). Here, the improv further slips into the audience’s “reality” when the black performer playing Actor 2 playing Black Man repeats “I have been black all my life.” Meanwhile, the white men tell each other racist jokes, ending with a final joke:

White Man I heard a joke once –
Punch-line: White Man shows off a noose. (100)

They wrap the prop noose around Black Man’s neck, throwing it over a “*beam or branch,*” when Black Man “*breaks character,*” shouting:

Help me.
 Seriously.
 Help me.
 Get this fucking thing off me” (101).

Using Harvey Young’s term, the noose is a “performance remain,” similar to a prop which is given meaning as the actor uses it onstage. A performance remain carries more meaning, and here the noose connotes direct, structural, and cultural violence. According to Young, both props

and performance remains evoke a sensation of “pleasure in seeing the relic revived, the dead metaphor made to speak again” (122). When White Man puts the noose around Black Man’s neck, the object’s meaning is resurrected onstage. The audience, whether it is pleasure or terror or something else, recognizes this prop as a performance remain of the thousands of lynchings of black Americans in the past. The noose and White Man’s use of it shocks the Actors, breaking the processtation. Actor 2 and Actor 6 exit when the noose is removed, leaving the remaining four actors in silence: “*And in that silence something starts to happen. The actors start to process what just happened. And there is something...*” (101). They begin laughing and the stage directions instruct: “*The actors might break, the moment might break, the momentum might break, the play might lose control, but the performers cannot stop until there is laughter, and it is genuine*” (102). In their shock, the actors do not know how to respond. The stage directions allow the performers to do anything as they laugh in that moment until the audience laughs with them—actors control of the performance and so do the stage directions.

However, the theatricality does not cease. Actor 4 gathers the props on the stage “*which have come to hold significance,*” leaving the noose for last (102). The noose remains as a performance remain of the direct violence then and in the past. Mitchell explains that Americans understood the theatricality of lynchings and the meaning their remains left: “A mutilated black body hanging from a tree was theatrical,” just as “a black man, woman, or child grinning was theatrical” (Mitchell 97). The actors, who have just broke character in the play-within-the-play, break again in the play, becoming as the stage directions say “*performers*” (102). At the end, Actor 4 goes to “*say something to the audience*”:

He might produce the air of a word beginning with the letter ‘w’ like ‘We’ or ‘Why’ or ‘What.’
He tries to speak, but he fails.
End of play. (102).

By ending on a soft consonant that fails to become a full thought, or even a full word, the actors of the play fail to represent the characters they devise. Furthermore, the performers themselves fail. In rehearsals, Drury describes watching the performers “[fail] to make the same kind of play that I failed to make” (qtd. Willis 205). Failure here, as Drury implies, is inevitable; she achieves failure with metatheatricality. Self-referentiality as a form is often employed with difficult subject matter because it serves as a disclaimer, allowing the artists to warn the audience that they are aware of the difficulty of the content and that they might fail in representing it.

Jackie Sibblies Drury further maximizes the metatheatricality by drawing parallels of direct, structural, and cultural violence in both the genocide of the Herero of Namibia and slavery of American history. Furthermore, the play demonstrates the difficult and perhaps impossible task of representing representations of violence adequately onstage. Failure is similarly seen in *An Octoroon* whenever BJJ breaks character, especially when he is unable to execute in performance his idea to replace the photo of the murder with a lynching photograph. In representing direct violence, failure to do so fully is inevitable. Metatheatricality allows the performance to acknowledge this difficult by complicating levels of perception. The play begins with legible distinctions between “Process” in the play’s reality and “Presentation” in the actors’ performance, but these distinctions are never fully stable and by the end the representation too closely signifies the violence of American history. According to Willis, “metatheatrical mimesis produces something greater than itself—something invisible and yet deeply powerful and real is released at that moment” (208). What is released cannot be articulated, only felt viscerally. Actor 4 cannot end the performance with language. He leaves the audience with only the visceral experience of racism, threatening what Ta-Nehisi Coates calls a “the Dream” (11).

Antoinette Nwandu's *Pass Over* similarly ends with a threat to the Dream. While, the play does not share the heavy reliance on a metatheatrical mode or historical subject matter of the previous plays, it does contain some of the same characteristics. A riff of *Waiting for Godot*, Nwandu places two young black men, Moses and Kitch, on the corner of 6th and King Drive on the Southside of Chicago, who are visited by a white man named Mister. Though not all audience members would know *Godot*, the play is metatheatrical in its intertextuality. Additionally, the final monologue given by the character Mister after he shoots Moses is direct address and acknowledges the audience's reaction to the representation onstage. Originally, the play had a different ending for its premiere in the summer of 2016 at Steppenwolf and the subsequent film of the play directed by Spike Lee. In the original ending, Mister assures the audience that everything is alright, the Dream has been restored: "We have done what we were meant to do. We stood our ground. We caught the bad guys. We took back what was ours" (*Pass Over*). In an American Theatre Magazine interview accompanying the full script of the play, Nwandu explains that the original "was so specific to that summer and that moment" after Trump took office, but she later felt it "hit [the audience] over the head with a sledgehammer" (qtd. Sinha 55). In the version published in American Theatre Magazine's September 2018 issue, Mister does not reaffirm the Dream so explicitly, but his Dream is threatened when the two men plan to leave their block. In this version, after he shoots Moses Mister says to the audience:

MISTER: golly gee
 did you guys hear
 a fella was killed today
 black fella
 another black fella was killed
 I should say
 well, because, well gosh
 it just keeps
 (*He makes a gesture for "happening"*)
 which is sad

you know
 so sad
 but also
 gosh
 so darn perplexing
 how does something like this keep—
 (*Again, he makes the “happening” gesture*) (Nwandu 72).

He continues stammering and unable to say “happening,” and ends the play with a sigh:

Then his demeanor brightens.
MISTER: anyway...
Blackout.

And with that, the Dream is quietly restored. As in the end of *We Are Proud* when Actor 4 cannot say anything following the violence, Mister is unable to acknowledge the happening of the violence or say anything of substance. Although it is late in the play, the metatheatricality in the final monologue is an essential component of the dramaturgy of the play. The violence is too much and breaks the performance, which requires a shift into metatheatricality to help Mister and the audience deal with the aftermath of another death of a black man.

In various forms, the word “happen” appears frequently in these three plays. In *An Octoroon*, Minnie and Dido, the two women slaves who provide comic relief, use the word to describe violent events like the sale of a woman’s baby after its birth and chopping off a man’s finger. Pete also says “happened” later when describing Paul’s murder by M’Closky. Near the end of *We Are Proud*, before the “Processtation,” Actor 4 (Another Black Man) asserts “everything we’re talking about happened to real people, a whole people, not just one family, thousands of families,” referring to the Herero genocide (87). Happening carries significance in these plays as a marker of violence occurring. In *Pass Over*, Mister is unable to fully acknowledge the violence happening in the present. Additionally, the plays blur the meaning of events, happening, doing, and performing. When Actor 1 calls the Herero genocide a “rehearsal

Holocaust” for the Germans, Actor 4 says “It’s not a rehearsal if you’re actually doing it” (88). In this moment, the actors are arguing over the distinction between rehearsal and performance, leading to the ending that fuses performance and reality because the noose around Actor 2’s neck happened, even if it was in improvisation.

Complicity watching, the audience witnesses these happenings and doings and rehearsals because at this point, as Fischer-Lichte argues, the audience recognizes the tenuous distinctions between reality and theatre. Young references Elias Canetti’s description of the audience as murder in lynchings: “The real executioner is the crowd. . . . It approves the spectacle and, with passionate excitement, gathers from far and near to watch it from beginning to end. It wants it to happen and hates being cheated of its victim” (qtd. 118). Human beings are both attracted to and repulsed by events of direct violence. In watching violence onstage, the audience might not be excited in the same manner of the lynch mobs, but there is a repulsive attraction to violence onstage that contemporary dramaturgies must contend with and artists must consider in representing violence.

Vandenbroucke says the existence of all forms of violence onstage demonstrates that “human beings are instinctively and perennially violent,” but he also points out that in the span of human history, the present is a relative era of peace (115). Yet, while direct violence is deemphasized, violence is still present structurally and culturally. Because violence is simultaneously an attractive and repulsive event for people to witness, in any media, it will likely never disappear as a dramatic device. Though direct violence is useful in exposing the cultural and structural violence, these plays demonstrate representations of direct violence risk breaking performances losing control and resurrecting terror of the past.

Young provides some help in navigating this ethical area by comparing two museum displays of lynching. In James Allen's *Without Sanctuary* exhibition, photographs of lynchings are displayed with little or no context, almost like a collection of terrible images that revive their original intent for white audiences and black audiences. However, in America's Black Holocaust Museum, the original exhibits did provide context alongside the performance remains of lynchings displayed by Dr. Cameron, a lynching survivor himself. The exhibit was still intended "to overwhelm, to horrify, to offend, and to enlighten" and did so much that the bit of rope, the wax figures hanging, and the photographs were all removed (Young 132). However, the museum also depicted the victims alive, as once living human beings. While most photographs of lynchings only show the victim dead, Young points to a few extant collections of series of photographs documenting lynchings from beginning to end. He argues these allow the present-day spectator to "witness not only to the loss of life but also, and perhaps more importantly, to the transformation of a living, sentient subject into an object to be destroyed" (133). Young argues Emmett Till's mother used the same strategy by displaying a photograph of Emmett alive with his open casket. Showing life alongside death humanizes "the objectified black body at the heart of the lynching spectacle"—displaying only the photographs after death gives no context and risks becoming a spectacle of terror again (132-133).

Drury, Jacobs-Jenkins, and Nwandu each represent the victims of their contemporary lynching plays more as living black American than as mutilated, dead bodies. In theatre, the performer and audience share the same space for the event and, as Young also argues, by being in proximity with another person one is compelled to "deal," "engage," and "interact" with the person (122). Live performance does not guarantee compassion, "but it does mandate a recognition" of the person as a person (122). In theatre, the person is an actor playing a character

but in metatheatre distinctions between person/actor/performer/character are complicated to the point of obliteration. The audience recognizes racism viscerally as an act of violence enacted upon the black body. Ontologically, therefore, theatre is best-suited medium for depicting direct violence of lynching and interrogating the structural and cultural violence of America's past.

Fischer-Lichte argues that in the theatre of the past 25 years, the "dichotomy" of real and fictional to describe perception is "undermined" (27). Furthermore, she argues this dichotomy serves as a "[regulator] for our behavior and actions" and by destabilizing "our perception of the world," it is possible to "[shatter] the norms and rules that guide our behavior" (27). For her, the "appropriate strategy for our present times" in theatre is staging "irritation, collision of frames, destabilization of perception and self—in a nutshell: provoking a state of crisis" (27).

Metatheatricality invites a state of crisis and by complicating the distinctions between audience perceptions of actors onstage, contemporary Black drama possesses the potential to alter the structural and cultural violence that allows direct violence. This potential is maximized when dramatists represent the terror of American history in a self-referential frame that emphasizes the same "dignified presence of the black body" the original lynching dramas emphasized in the early 20th century (Mitchell 97).

The contemporary master of interrogating American history in Black drama, Suzan-Lori Parks believes the "theatre is a healing thing" (582). In fact, she encourages theatre artists reopen the wound of racism left by slavery because "when it healed up last time it healed up wrong, [...] our thoughts healed up wrong" (81). Using the language of direct violence, Parks is arguing that black plays can heal those wounds and alter the structural and cultural violence of America. Coates describes optimism for a future free of racism as "specious hope," but he does conclude by explaining to his son that "the constant interrogation" of the racism and its violence on the

black body, “freed me from ghosts and girded me against the sheer terror of disembodiment”

(10). Interrogating violence in all its form through representation in live performance offers Americans an opportunity to confront our history. While threatening “the Dream,” black drama utilizes metatheatricality to represent direct violence ethically. Because theatre is a live and present art form and requires embodiment of the victims, black theatre, which is contemporary American theatre, is well positioned to ethically represent American violence past and present.

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